

however, the dissolution of the Bihar Assembly in May 2005, when he acted on the advice of the Centre, a move that was widely condemned and even declared unconstitutional by the Supreme Court. Kalam's defence is that even though he was in Russia at that time, he had discussions with Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and had the relevant documents transmitted to him electronically before he took the decision. But the issue proved a setback to his image of an impartial constitutional head. He did try to correct that impression by locking horns with the Government on the Office of Profit Bill but now plays it down, saying he achieved what he wanted.

Politics was clearly not his forte and that perhaps was his biggest advantage. He brought with him no political baggage and unlike earlier presidents like Giani Zail Singh and Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed who misused their presidency by indulging in unashamed political acquiescence, Kalam, in his eccentric, ide-

■ **Dissolution of Bihar Assembly where the office of the President came under criticism. The SC ruling that the dissolution was not within the provisions of the Constitution created some embarrassment for the President.**

■ **Raised questions on the Right To Information Act and sent a note to the prime minister suggesting some cautious rethink on the issue.**

■ **Afzal Guru's mercy petition, pending for more than six months now, is supposedly stalled with the President. Though he now says he did not receive the papers from the Home Ministry, the impression was that he was bowing to the Government's wishes.**

THE LOWS

SIRAJA DAS

THE HIGHS

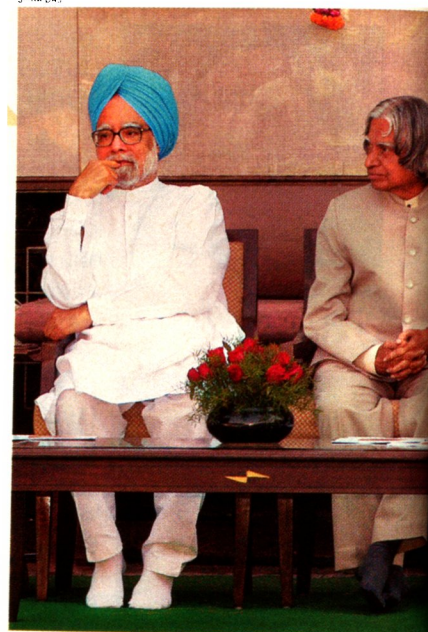
■ **Described the riots in Gujarat as "the most gruesome" and said the Government would adopt a model law to deal with communal violence.**

■ **Refused to approve the Office of Profit Bill. Highlighted flaws in the proposed law.**

■ **Became the first supreme commander of the armed forces to visit troops in Siachen glacier, the first to go undersea in a submarine, and also the first to fly in a supersonic fighter aircraft—Sukhoi-30 MKI.**

■ **Made Rashtrapati Bhavan a people's Bhavan and was the most tech-savvy President.**

SIRAJA DAS



BALANCING ACT: Good relations with Manmohan, less so with Sonia

alistic and professorial way, gave himself the space and time to insulate himself from the political establishment and add value to the office like few had before him (see rating box). He was the first scientist and the first bachelor to occupy the presidential post but beyond scientific theory is the fact that he was a thinker, mentor and inspirational leader. Unlike some of his predecessors, Kalam never had hangers-on, groupies or even relatives staying with him in the 353-room Viceregal mansion. In fact, during his tenure, he paid for every single relative who was invited to stay with him. As Professor Rajeev Sanghal, director, Indian Institute of Information Technology (IIT), Hyderabad, says: "He set the moral agenda for the nation."

Indeed, Kalam's greatest achievement has been to restore dignity, grace and inspirational leadership the presidency, things that were sorely lacking previously. Jawaharlal Nehru had favoured the appointment of only 'eminent' persons even though the first President of independent India, Rajendra Prasad, was more than a handful for Nehru, both because of his conservative views and his tendency to transgress the limited role ascribed to

